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AWAY WINS

As soon as the World Cup was over I consulted a series of specialists and was advised to have an operation on the ring finger of my left hand because of calcification. There was no other option and in April 2003 I travelled to Baltimore, USA, with my family to get the surgery done. Dr Anant Joshi, as on many occasions in the past, was with me, and his reassuring presence, together with that of my friends Vini Desai and Paresh Bhakta, was always a great source of strength in moments like these.

The surgical process turned out to be slightly out of the ordinary because I was not the best patient. I was extremely worried that the doctors would cut open my palm. Cutting the palm would mean substantially altering my grip, which I really didn't want to do. I explained to both my surgeons the nuances of cricket and urged them to cut open the back of the hand. I was so obsessed with this issue that I woke up during the surgery and asked them to show me where they had made the incision. Dr Joshi later told me that they were all surprised to see me awake despite the anaesthesia. The doctors showed me that my palm had been left untouched and told me to calm down and allow them to carry on. Satisfied, I instantly drifted back to sleep.

The surgery kept me off the field for close to four months. There was not much cricket scheduled then and I missed only one tour, of Bangladesh, in the period I was out. The recovery was painful and, as often happens, I jarred the hand on a number of occasions during the period of convalescence. The one time I hurt it really badly was when I was holidaying in London in June 2003. Anjali and I went out for dinner